



| NIGERIAN PEOPLES AND CULTURE



POLICE BRUTALITY, ENDSARS CRISIS, THE 2023 ELECTION AND YOUTH POLITICAL AWAKENING

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LEARNING OBJECTIVE

At the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Analyse the connection between police brutality and youth reawakening in Nigeria.
- Describe the focus of the EndSARS crisis.
- Examine its impact on the 2023 elections.





INTRODUCTION

Nigerian youth, who make up roughly 60% of the population, are a significant influence on the future of the country. However, if not effectively utilised, this big youth population could potentially lead to uprisings like to the 2011 Arab Spring.

The fact that a similar pattern was seen in 2020 demonstrates that youth upheavals are not unheard of in Nigeria. The elections in 2023 brought attention to the value of youth engagement and the unhappiness of young people with the current system of government.





INTRODUCTION

After years of abuse, Nigerian youths began to speak up against police brutality and indiscriminate profiling. In October 2020, Nigerian youths rose to protest the continuous operation of a department of the police force known as SARS. The protest lasted for three weeks and ended with the Nigerian army shooting at unarmed protesters.





POLICE BRUTALITY

In Nigeria, excessive use of force, extrajudicial killings, harassment, and power abuse by law enforcement agencies have all been long-standing problems. The #EndSARS movement, which gained significant momentum in October 2020, brought international attention to this issue. The movement called for an end to police brutality and demanded accountability for the actions of the now-disbanded Special Anti-Robbery Squad (SARS).





POLICE BRUTALITY

While the protests initially started as a response to police brutality, they soon became a broader demand for good governance, transparency, and an end to systemic corruption. The Nigerian government responded with promises of police reform and investigations into the misconduct of security personnel. However, progress in implementing these reforms has been slow, and there have been reports of continued cases of police brutality since the protests subsided.





POLICE BRUTALITY

Moses Ochonu argues that the Nigerian Police have not been decolonised. In the colonial period, the Nigerian police were about "suppression of revolts" rather than protection; "brute force was the primary operating philosophy of the police."

Abimbola Oyarinu posits that SARS began during a moment of turmoil for Nigeria: "the falling and failing economy after the oil boom, the depreciating naira, the Nigerian civil war, the Structural Adjustment Programme, and poor leadership." All these factors culminated in creating an environment ripe for insecurity and violent crimes."





POLICE BRUTALITY

The Cable identified 91 deaths caused by police actions between March 2019 and February 2020.

The courts and the judicial system at the time were either too slow, inefficient, incompetent, or not respected enough to impose justice on the police force. Erring officers were not sanctioned as they boasted openly about taking lives without repercussion.



MID-LESSON QUESTION

How has police brutality affected trust between law enforcement and the community, and what measures can be taken to address and prevent instances of this brutality?





THE END SARS CRISIS

#EndSARS is a decentralised social movement and series of mass protests against police brutality in Nigeria. The agitation began with a call for the disbanding of the Special Anti-Robbery Squad (SARS), a unit of the police, which has been attributed to a host of unlawful activities, especially against youths. The protest began as a hashtag on Twitter in 2017 and metamorphosed into a crisis in October 2020. The immediate cause of the crisis was a shooting captured on video in which a police officer targeted an unarmed civilian.





END SARS CRISIS

The 2020 Endsars protest saw thousands of Nigerian youths storm the streets to protest against police brutality and extrajudicial killings. Two correctional facilities in Edo State were attacked, public and private properties were vandalised, and business premises were looted. On October 20th, 2020, the Nigerian Army opened fire on protesters at the Lekki toll gate, killing and injuring scores of peaceful protesters. The movement created a record of 10 million new registered voters for the February 25th and March 11th elections.





SOCIAL MEDIA AND THE END SARS CRISIS

The October protest against police brutality was not the first time Nigerian youths would protest against police brutality, but this time, they harnessed the power of social media to draw both local and international attention to their plight.

Like the Arab Spring, Nigerian youths used social media to distribute e-flyers detailing the time and location of the protest. The protest soon spread nationwide but was not popular in the northern part of the country. Twitter was especially deployed to achieve its purpose.





ENDSARS

The Security forces responded harshly to the protesters, resulting in sad incidents of violence and loss of life. The Nigerian government's first attempts to quell protesters aggravated the situation, but the government finally dissolved SARS and promised significant police reform. However, there has been little discernible success.



POST-ENDSARS

Just one year after the #EndSARS crisis, Global Rights recorded 164 cases of extrajudicial killings between January and September 2021. This indicates that not much has changed after the crisis, and the Nigerian police need systemic reform.

In the south-east alone, Amnesty International records 52 incidences of unlawful killings and 62 cases of arbitrary arrest, ill treatment, and torture in 4 months from January 2021.



2023 ELECTIONS

After the unfortunate incident of October 20, 2020, a lot of youth decided to take action and take their anger to the polls.

The result was that the election saw a lot of youth participation. Around 76% of newly registered voters were young people, and 40% of those numbers registered as students.

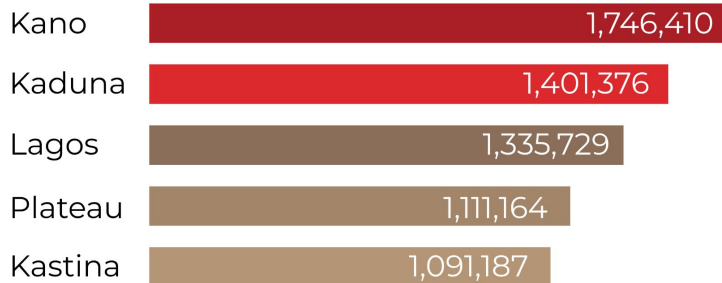




2023 ELECTIONS

The Nigerian election this year had a huge number of young voters; numerous causes prompted youth to participate, the most frequent of which was the way the EndSARS protest ended, which resulted in the loss of so many lives.

Despite the huge attendance of youngsters, the countrywide voter turnout was 29%; no election in Nigeria's six decades of independence has had a lower participation rate. This year, 87.2 million of the 93.4 million registered voters obtained their Permanent voter cards.





YOUTH REAWAKENING

The #EndSARS protests and the broader youth movement in Nigeria have sparked a significant political awakening among the country's youth. Young Nigerians have become increasingly engaged in political discourse, demanding accountability and actively participating in political activities.

This youth political awakening has led to increased civic engagement, including the formation of youth-led advocacy groups, participation in voter registration drives, and calls for increased representation of young people in political offices. Social media has played a crucial role in amplifying the voices of young Nigerians and facilitating the organisation of collective action.



SUMMARY

In October 2020, Nigerian youths rose to protest the continuous operation of a department of the police force known as SARS. The protest lasted for three weeks and ended with the Nigerian army shooting at unarmed protesters.

The #EndSARS protests and the broader youth movement in Nigeria have sparked a significant political awakening among the country's youth. Young Nigerians have become increasingly engaged in political discourse, demanding accountability and actively participating in political activities.



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THANK YOU